

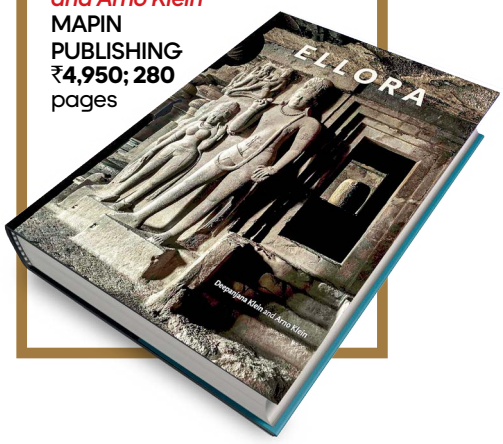
BEAUTY CARVED IN BASALT
Arno Klein's pictures elevate the grey-black tones and rough textures of the basalt rock that give the carved figures at Ellora their character

BOOKS ▼

IF STONES COULD SING

The photographs in *Ellora* complement the in-depth essays, which establish it as one of a series of sites across the Deccan with a distinct artistic style

ELLORA: Cross-Fertilization of Style in Buddhist, Hindu and Jain Cave Temples
By Deepanjana Klein and Arno Klein
MAPIN PUBLISHING
₹4,950; 280 pages



There can never be too many books with photographs of Ellora, surely one of the most visually stunning archaeological sites in the world, developed between the sixth and the ninth centuries CE. So magnificent and overwhelming are the caves that the images will always dwarf (literally and metaphorically) whatever is written about them. This book, by Deepanjana Klein and Arno Klein, is no exception to that rule despite the pretty solid essays it contains. Ellora's rock carvings demand to be represented in black and white images and, here, Arno Klein's pictures masterfully elevate the grey-black tones and rough textures of the basalt rock that give the carved figures their character. His photos capture the stillness of the Buddhist figures, the dynamism of Shiva and Vishnu in their iconic postures (Nataraja, Vamana, Narasimha), the austere intimacy of the vihara and the vastness of a universe teeming with other beings. The Jain caves at Ellora have never been my favourite, but in a less dramatic way, even they have sculptures that catch your breath and give you pause.

THE PHOTOS CAPTURE BOTH THE STILLNESS OF THE BUDDHIST FIGURES AND THE DYNAMISM OF SHIVA AND VISHNU IN THEIR ICONIC POSTURES

More and more, we are seeing Ellora not as unique, but one in a series of sites across the Deccan Plateau, with a distinct style of artistic expression. The essays in this volume point to these stylistically continuous spaces across Ellora itself and to the similarities of structure and depiction that were maintained over centuries in the